



» ALT + TAB
ESPORTS DIGEST

The long game on the small screen

GEPL is betting that mobile cricket **can turn** casual gamers into professional esports athletes, build careers and even produce future Olympians.

Nigamanth P
nigamanth.p@thehindu.co.in

For long, the image of a youngster glued to a mobile phone has come with a familiar parental warning: put it down and focus on your studies. But the organisers of the Global e-Cricket Premier League (GEPL) believe mobile gaming is beginning to challenge that, turning something millions of Indians already do into a sporting ecosystem that can create careers, stars and, eventually, Olympic athletes.

For Rajan Navani, founder and chairman of JetSynthesys — the company behind Real Cricket and GEPL — the bet on mobile gaming

was made years before esports became a mainstream conversation in India.

"Competitive gaming can go to scale only with mobile," Navani said. "If you have to pay money, your entry barrier becomes much higher. But mobile gaming and free-to-play make it accessible."

Real Cricket has recorded around 400 million downloads over 12 years, he said, creating the funnel from which competitive players emerge. That funnel has now taken the shape of GEPL. From six teams last year, the league has expanded to eight this season, while the number of games has grown from 34 to 62.

"We started out in season one, we took the entire risk," said Jogesh

Going down the wire: From millions of mobile gamers to a competitive sporting ecosystem, the GEPL is beginning to take shape. Chennai Falcons capped the latest chapter by beating Mumbai Grizzlies 2-1 in a tense final. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Lulla, COO of JetSynthesys. "Come season two, people started noticing what we were trying to do. Now, in season three, we've proved our concept, and we want to grow more."

"The competition is already intense", Lulla said. "We've gone from 12,000 people who qualified, narrowed it down to 100, and only 64 got selected in the auction. This is from 1.5 million people who play every day and 20 million who play every month."

That, organisers argue, is why these players shouldn't be dismissed as kids playing video games. "They are athletes, not kids playing video games. They practise six to eight hours a day to get as good as they are," Lulla said.

For GEPL to grow, perceptions in India must shift too. "Majority of parents feel mobile gaming will take you nowhere. But it's not either this or that — I have seen players juggle between a full-time job and gaming," Lulla said.

Navani sees esports as part of a larger shift in how young Indians could build careers. "Every job is getting automated. So being able to be creative, be an athlete, be in esports — these are going to be new professions," he said, adding that the ecosystem also supports casters, production staff and venue teams.

GEPL is also building from the grassroots, with boot camps and college activations to identify players. The biggest dream is the Olympics. "If everything falls in place, cricket is going to be part of the esports Olympics and these kids will represent India," Lulla said. For Navani, an Olympic medal would be "hugely gratifying" — but first, GEPL wants to build the ecosystem that can produce the athletes to chase it.

The writer was at the event at the invitation of GEPL.